

STUDENT SESSION • THE COMET

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

A note from Deja, who runs The Comet, the school paper: "You're on the fact team. Three writers used an AI helper. Remember: AI guesses the most likely words — it does not check them — so it can be completely wrong and still sound sure. No story gets printed until you check it."

Desk words: run = it gets printed · clear = it passes the check · log = write it down · second source = a place to check that is NOT where you first saw the claim · "the ending still stands" = it is still true once the facts are fixed

Your method, every draft: **1. UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes). **2. RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones. **3. LATERAL-READ** — leave the draft. Log a second source that could confirm each C. **4. VERDICT** — tick a stamp, give your evidence, and say if the writer's ending still stands.

🔍 DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN, "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. By 1972, twelve people had walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐ **RUN** — clean, print it
 ☐ **FIX** — correct it, then print
 ☐ **KILL** — cut the story

Note to Priya — what's wrong, your second source, and does her ending still stand?

🔍 DRAFT #2 — THEO'S QUIZ PAGE, "WORLD RECORDS CORNER"

Same method: underline the checkable claims · C = check it, S = safe · log a second source (NOT where you first saw it) · tick a stamp and write your note.

The Pacific Ocean is the largest ocean on Earth. The Nile River flows north through Egypt and is one of the longest rivers in the world. The tallest mountain above sea level is Mount Everest, which rises in the Andes range in South America. Earth has seven continents, and the largest is Asia. Australia's capital city is Sydney. Put it together and the record-holders sit on three continents: Africa, South America, and Asia.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐	RUN — clean, print it	☐	FIX — correct it, then print	☐	KILL — cut the story
--------------------------	------------------------------	--------------------------	-------------------------------------	--------------------------	-----------------------------

Note to Theo — what's wrong, your second source, and does his ending still stand?

🔍 DESK HELPERS — USE THESE ON DRAFTS #2 AND #3

RANK: which claims get a C?

- Dates, names, numbers, and quotes — easy to get wrong, easy to check.
- Words like *first*, *only*, *biggest*, *tallest* — record claims are risky.
- Anything the ending depends on. If it falls, the story falls.
- Mark **S** when everybody already knows it. You can't check everything.

Second sources that count

- A textbook or an encyclopedia entry on the topic.
- A museum, space agency, or government website.
- A different website that did not copy the first one.

Does NOT count: asking the same AI again · the draft itself · "I'd Google it" with no source named.

DRAFT #3 — MARCUS’S FEATURE, “THE INVENTION ISSUE”

Same method: underline the checkable claims · C = check it, S = safe · log a second source (NOT where you first saw it) · tick a stamp and write your note. **Watch for this:** a quote is a claim too.

Thomas Edison invented the telephone in 1876. As Edison put it, "The telephone is the finest of all my inventions." The next year, in 1877, Edison invented the phonograph — the first machine that could both record and play back sound. A generation later, the Wright brothers made the first successful powered airplane flights in 1903, near Kitty Hawk, North Carolina. That record makes Edison the most important inventor of the 1800s.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐ **RUN** — clean, print it
 ☐ **FIX** — correct it, then print
 ☐ **KILL** — cut the story

Note to Marcus — what's wrong, your second source, and does his ending still stand?

EXIT TICKET — LAST CHECK

1. In your own words: how can AI sound 100% sure and still be wrong?

2. Name one checkable claim (a name, date, number, place, or quote) you saw online this week — or one you expect to see. Where would you check it? Name a second source that is NOT the place you first saw it (a textbook, an encyclopedia, a different website).

Desk rule to keep: smooth is not the same as true. Before you repeat it, post it, or hand it in — check it.